various Slovenian religious and patriotic societies bore the name of the two Greek brothers and today they are still associated with the Christian ecumenical movement.

Not all of the Slavic countries embraced the Pan-Slavic idea with the same enthusiasm, which reflects not only the sometimes controversial nature of such associations within the Slavic world, but also the variety of historical experiences that individual Eastern European countries (and Slavic countries among them) have had with Russia. Slovenia, on the other hand, is less troubled by such anxieties because there has never been a Russian military presence on Slovenian soil. (The only two exceptions are Russian prisoners of war held there during World War I and World War II, and the brief presence of the Red Army in the north-eastern corner of Slovenia, formerly occupied by Hungary, immediately after World War II.) Nurturing this, at surface, wholly non-controversial relationship was thus something that Slovenian politicians thought could only complement the country's main orientation towards the EU and NATO. Russians thought differently. A wooden World War I Orthodox chapel, built by Russian (and other) prisoners of war under Mt. Vršič, was relatively uncontroversial but the issue of World War II military presence has been less straightforward. Throughout the 2010s, the Russian government was zealously pursuing a campaign of erecting memorials to the Red Army soldiers at every possible location, amounting to what some saw as part of the imposition of a geopolitical narrative by President Putin – politically marking the territory. In any even scarce historical links with Russia were thus suddenly disproportionally represented in Slovenia. Other Eastern European countries, whose relationships with Russia have been, at best, ambivalent both in the past and the present, were particularly wary of such advances of Russian public diplomacy – they rather saw it as a part of hybrid warfare. During my years in Prague, the city borough of Prague 6 was engulfed in a conflict with the Russian embassy over the memorial to the Soviet Marshal Konev who led the army of the Soviet liberators of Prague in 1945. Konev infamously returned to Prague in 1968, on a much less noble mission. He had also been involved in the suppression of the Budapest uprising in 1956. It was this post-World War II engagement of his that eventually led the local authority to remove his statue in 2020, despite the protests of the Russian embassy and the local communist party. Similarly, at the height of Russian